Confronting American Apathy

By Ralph Black, Tony Hoagland and Raul Herrera

INTRODUCTION

Once upon a time in the United States of America, there lived a nation of citizens that showed tremendous interest in the state of their country's well-being. With incredible zeal, these citizens worked tirelessly to correct any local, national or international issue that threatened them either as individuals or collectively, showing no fear and great resolve while addressing any elected or appointed public official that didn't accurately represent their beliefs, ethics, morals and values. Once upon a time. . .

However, this state of involvement is no longer the norm for most U.S. citizens and hasn't been for nearly 40 years. I ask you this: Are you happy with the direction our society is taking, or have you given up hope that any action you take will bring about change?

Confronting American Apathy through poetry: 21st Century Lecture by Ralph Black, America by Tony Hoagland and Earthquake by Raul Herrera

21st Century Lecture by Ralph Black (Pg 185-187)

Listen. You know what a torn shirt
the world's become. You know how thin
its fabric. You know what seams are,
and how your life, as though by accident,

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settles in and trembles them apart.
And everyone knows you don't mean it.
So you say to yourself, don't be stupid.
You say, don't sham and swindle your way
through these stark desecrations,
don't stand around as your body's
warming waters rise, as they lift
and pool around the trunks
of three-hundred-year-old trees-
the ones that snatched away your breath
and all your words when you were a kid.
Your tea is getting cold. The shirts
you bought on a whim have to go back
to the Singapore sweatshop.
You're a smart enough guy, keening
over the paper each morning,
tuned in to just the right litany of fear –
Baghdad, Darfur, the Bronx-
the outstretched or instantly severed hand.
You could turn the page from the steady
unraveling of the planet's bright threads.
But your throat rasps and freezes at the sight

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of the sea lion sow chewing the face
off her newborn pup; at the Coho hatchlings
spilling out of the hatchery flume,
carrying their constellations of DNA
up and against the river's age-old equations;
at the polar bears starving at the edge
of their ice. You know the word *starving,*
you know the meaning of CO_2, you know
how apple seeds and smart bombs bloom,
how simple it is to flay a range of hills,
eviscerate a mountain with a spark.
You know how the stones can keep you warm.
You're not an idiot. You're not a fool.
You won't let your heart-that tiny,
glacial island-fracture and calve.
You think your love for your children
and your children's love for everything
but homework and spinach should be plenty.
The name of the wind is changing.
The wind, which you know is your breath,
and spills over flooded deltas, which churns
through the gleaming thickets of oil refineries,

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fission factories, wind farms, water mills,
think tanks, smelters, grinders, brothels,
landfills, gun shops, billboards declaring
the newest-brightest-best- You know
how it fills you, how it lifts away from you
the words you use to talk back to yourself
late into the night. It's a very old wind, and you
utter it over and over, a mantra, a koan,
a playing out of words like an old uncle spiraling
ten-pound test over his favorite run of rapids
thirty miles up the East Fork of that river
that spills now green and empty as an eye.
You know all this. No one's telling you anything
you haven't known for a hundred years.
But your tongue says *say it,* just the same.
Your mouth makes the shape of a call, a cry,
an uneven song. You reach for a pen,
tired as you are. You write it down, because
stories and maps are the same. You think
of the photograph you saw at the museum:
a ten-year-old boy born blind who lost
both his arms in his country's war.

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He's at a desk, reading a book with his mouth.

He's leaning in and kissing the words,

in love with his own hunger.

He's doing with his whole body

everything he knows how to do.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ralph Black
Book: The Ecopoetry Anthology, Pgs 185-187
ISBN: 978-1595341464
Publisher: Trinity University Press
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2013

TRANSITION

But what can I do, you ask . . . I can't solve these problems. I'm just one person. OK – fine, let's bring it down to an individual level. Let's talk about consumerism: the obsession with acquisition that has become the organizing principle of American life. You are part of a culture in which the people will do most anything to acquire the means to consume — work slavish hours, maybe even two jobs, buy homes beyond their means and think nothing of running up credit card debt. We've reached a crisis point – a crisis of consumerism – What can you do? Choose wisely . . . choose to stop acquiring "things" . . . and according to Tony Hoagland . . . wake up.

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America by Tony Hoagland (Pg 7-8)

Then one of the students with blue hair and a tongue stud
Says that America is for him a maximum-security prison

Whose walls are made of RadioShacks and Burger Kings, and MTV episodes
Where you can't tell the show from the commercials,

And as I consider how to express how full of s*** I think he is,
He says that even when he's driving to the mall in his Isuzu

Trooper with a gang of his friends, letting rap music pour over them
Like a boiling Jacuzzi full of ballpeen hammers, even then he feels

Buried alive, captured and suffocated in the folds
Of the thick satin quilt of America

And I wonder if this is a legitimate category of pain,
or whether he is just spin doctoring a better grade,

And then I remember that when I stabbed my father in the dream last night,
It was not blood but money

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That gushed out of him, bright green hundred-dollar bills
Spilling from his wounds, and—this is the weird part—,
He gasped "Thank god—those Ben Franklins were
Clogging up my heart—

And so I perish happily,
Freed from that which kept me from my liberty"—

Which was when I knew it was a dream, since my dad
Would never speak in rhymed couplets,

And I look at the student with his acne and cell phone and phony ghetto clothes
And I think, "I am asleep in America too,
And I don't know how to wake myself either,"
And I remember what Marx said near the end of his life:

"I was listening to the cries of the past,
When I should have been listening to the cries of the future."

But how could he have imagined 100 channels of 24-hour cable
Or what kind of nightmare it might be

When each day you watch rivers of bright merchandise run past you
And you are floating in your pleasure boat upon this river

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Even while others are drowning underneath you
And you see their faces twisting in the surface of the waters

And yet it seems to be your own hand
Which turns the volume higher?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tony Hoagland
Book: What Narcissism Means to Me, Pgs 7-8
ISBN: 978-1555973865
Publisher: Graywolf Press
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2003

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier
Poems from What Narcissism Means to Me

TRANSITION

The final poem in this collection is Earthquake by Raul Herrera. In it he implores all individuals to use their voices to elicit change -- to speak out. The vibration of our collective voices will have as much power as the vibrations of an Earthquake by Raul Herrera

Earthquake by Raul Herrera (Pg 2-4)

In 1906 an 8.2 sized earthquake ruptured the San Andreas Fault, killing an estimated 3,000 people.

If vibrations break boulders and devastate lives,

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Then our words can split open minds and alter the geo-
graphical shape of its content.
Because sound is vibration.
Our verbs are its earthquakes
And our hands are much like the Richter scale.
Charting the magnitude of our words.
So when you write,
Fight the urge to destroy your enemies.
Because and earthquake,
Named Gandhi
once told me,
Even revenge has aftershocks.
That even a whisper
Can cause a revolution.
In 2010 a 7.0-sizedearthquake takes the lives of 300,000
Haitians.
Do not underestimate
The Hercules behind your tongue.
Your voices are the reasons this planet's axis is tilted.
But your silence is the reason this planet is dying.
So let's cause a ruckus!
If Earthquakes can destroy lives,

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Our voices can rebuild them.
In 2011 a 9.0-earthquake demolishes Fukushima, Japan.
"I have been to the mountaintop and I looked over and I've
seen the
Promised land."
But the only thing in our way
Is a mute mountain.
So we
Crumble mountains.
We
Crack Rock
without needing a pipe.
Just give me a word.
One sentence can make the ground move like a Tsunami.
You can see their words cracking the concrete.
Cracking
Like the backs of the rebels from the past.
Cracking
Like the blast that killed 2Pac's laugh.
Malcolm exited this world
believing that his earthquake would cause repercussions
"The future belongs to those who prepare for it today."

So today I have a dream.
But my dream wasn't heard
Today I have a dream
But my dream was deferred
Today I had a dream about a King but the king wasn't heard.
The legends are angry.
The world is violent
While we stay . . .
Why?
Newton's 3rd law states,
"For every action there is an equal and opposite reaction."
For example, if the action is
division
Then the opposite reaction would be
communication
Problems react to solutions.
Oppression reacts to revolution.
The death of Trayvon Martin reacts to Zimmerman's
prosecution.
Now this is law.

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Voices react to vibrations,
Vibrations react to earthquakes.
So if sound is vibration
Our verbs are its earthquakes.
So let's break the ground our fallen heroes are trapped
underneath.
Resurrect poets from graves.
REACT
Leaders from being slayed
REACT
Let's speak with tremors trembling towers>
Talk like an earthquake.
Be like a rock,
And watch this granite planet
Shake

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Raul Herrera
Book: Get Lit Rising, Pgs 2-4
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